LArPix ASICs on PACMAN

Bench setup, configuration, replies and status

Maintained by the PACMAN agents (augie)

2026-11-01

1 Purpose and scope

This note records the LArPix ASIC work on PACMAN with the zipline firmware and software (`zipline.tex`): which ASICs are on the bench, how they are configured, what they reply, and what is open. Register numbers are those of the LArPix v3 register map in `larpix-lib` (`config/asics/larpix_v3.yaml`), which agrees with the LBNL datasheet (rev 2.4, not public). The datasheet has known errors: its bit layouts and defaults are not trusted until they are read back from a chip.

2 Bench setup

- One LArPix v3 on a single-tile board, on tile 1. On the 1v4 it is reached through the J1302 cable, with all four PISO/POSI pairs routed to the tile-1 UARTs 0–3.
- Chip ID 0x0B (11). The hello request is a configuration read of register 122 (the chip ID); the expected reply is `0x42254139 1C2DE82F` ("read, chip 0x0B, register 122, value 0x0B").
- Tile power by `pacman_menu` (VDDA about 2.32 V, VDDD about 1.20–1.30 V, a few mA each). The 1v4 needs I2C at 100 kHz with this cable (now the default).
- Unplug any signal source from the LEMO inputs before connecting ASICs.
- In scripted menu sequences: RX UARTs all off first (`u`), then power, a 2 s wait (a monitor read right after power-on shows 0 mV), full reset, wait, configuration, wait, and channel 0 on (the second `u`) only when ready to receive. With channel 0 listening through reset and configuration, it often fills with random words.
- After a full reset, wait (0.2 s is enough) before configuring: the reset returns at once, and a configuration sent during it is lost. A pollable reset state register is set aside for later.

3 Configuration root

The configuration root (`pacman_menu`, `asic_config_root` in `asic_menu.c`) brings a chip up as the root of a chain:

Register	Value	Meaning
125	0x1	downstream PISO enables: PISO 0
124	0x2	upstream PISO enables: PISO 1
239, 240	0xFF	PISO drive: every TX slice enabled
241, 242	0x00	PISO drive current (`i_tx_diff`, active low): full

The drive settings were added on 2026-10-31 (pacman-software 6d2ad8e) after the 1v4 results below.

4 Results

Date	Board	Result
2026-10-30	1v5	Hello on UART 0 at the power-on drive: the expected reply, exactly. POSI request and PISO reply also decoded bit-exact from oscilloscope captures at the tile connector.
2026-10-30	1v4	At the power-on drive, the same wrong word on all four lanes (`0xFE000000 70387FC0`): the reply framed 7 bits late, with bit errors. All TX slices (239, 240 = 0xFF): exact on UARTs 0 and 1. Plus full current (241, 242 = 0x00): exact on all four.
2026-10-31	1v4	With 124 = 0x2 and full drive: exact on UART 0, and the built-in logic analyzer shows the request on POSI 0 and the exact reply on PISO 0, 8.2 µs later. PISO 2 and 3 (enabled neither up- nor downstream) stream junk into the receivers at full drive.
2026-10-31	1v4	Latest build (firmware 928fcf0, software 3c9b2d0), configuration root as built: the reply exact, twice.
2026-11-01	1v4	Software 671a3dd, the same sequence as a piped script: no reply (UART 0 streams junk). Cause: the configuration root sent right after the full reset is lost; the full reset returns at once, and the new menu input no longer sleeps between commands. With a 0.2 s pause after the full reset: the reply exact, twice.
2026-11-01	1v4	Software 290979d, a 16-BD DMA ring set up from the menu, with the 0.2 s pause: the reply exact, twice.
2026-11-01	1v4	Drive scan with the ASIC loopback test (800 readbacks of random register values per point): at the power-on current (241 = 0xCC) no slice setting (239 = 0x11 to 0xFF) passes; with all slices on, the current passes from 241 = 0x88 (0 errors) to 0x00, 0x99 is marginal (22 errors), 0xAA and weaker fail; one timeout at 0x22. Repeated with the RX buffer's heartbeat and rollover words off: the same threshold, and 0x22 passes (the timeout was those words in the stream).
2026-11-01	1v5	Old image (f516bc7), scripted: no reply and a stream of random words on UART 0, from the script's order (channel 0 on through reset and configuration; the monitor read before the regulators were up). By hand, and scripted in the order above: the reply exact (4 of 4); the register read-all valid throughout.
2026-11-01	1v5	Software 290979d: ASIC loopback 800 of 800 at full drive. Drive scan: every point passes except zero current (241 = 0xFF); one slice (239 = 0x11) passes at 241 = 0xCC, and the smallest current (241 = 0xEE) passes with all slices. The 1v5 needs far less drive than the 1v4.
2026-11-02	1v5	Configured by larpix-lib (branch working-on-asic-config, `demos/init_network.py` from felix, through `pacman_cmdserver`): 13 configuration writes (chip ID 1 to 11, I/O, drive 0x77, PISO 0 downstream). Then a menu hello without the configuration root: the reply exact, 3 of 3. Before it, after a full reset, hello had no reply. The menu needs a running RX ring: restarting the cmdserver resets the DMA, so the dataserver is started once after it and killed.

5 Open

- Systematic adjustment of the PISO drive (registers 239–242, and `v_cm_lvds_tx` 254–255) and of the PISO enables (124, 125): why the 1v4 needs far more drive than the 1v5 (which passes at one slice or the smallest current), why UARTs 2 and 3 need more than 0 and 1, and whether disabled PISOs at full drive are undriven or biased without data.

- The real bit layouts and defaults: a read-all of the registers on the 1v5, recorded (run by hand on 2026-11-01, not kept).
- ASIC stress tests on the 1v5 (later).
- LArPix v2b on the hw1v4: v2 clocks its UART at MCLK/2 (v3 at MCLK).